



00:30
Stand in a queue to get your baggage X-rayed

01:00
Get stuck at immigration due to shortage of manned counters

Aircraft circling waiting to land

00:30
The plane spends half an hour idling before take-off

an expectation of improvement and some activity, it is a tribute to the doughty fighter that Civil Aviation Minister Praful Patel is. Despite the raging Reds, he has managed to unleash reforms in the sector. His theory has been to make the boom drive the redevelopment of airports; to make public pressure for infrastructure drive private and public initiative. The demand-led model is good economic theory. But when grounded in India, it delivers chaos. Thanks to the unprecedented boom—aviation logged 34 per cent growth last year—the ugly underbelly of aviation infrastructure is badly exposed.

You would have heard of ground delays. But India specialises in air traffic jams. Nearly half of all flights coming to Mumbai and Delhi are delayed with aircraft circling the airports in a "hold pattern" for at least half an hour during peak hours or worse, sitting on the tarmac, their idling engines burning precious avia-

per year or nearly the cost of the new airport at Bangalore and five lakh tonnes of emissions every year.

Business travellers shuttling between Mumbai and Delhi have adjusted to the now de rigueur airline delays by investing in video-conferencing, holding meetings closer to the airports and sometimes boarding flights a day earlier to be on time for meetings. "I can never rely on an airline to be on time," says Delhi-based Harinder Sikka, director-corporate affairs, Nicholas Piramal, who recently missed a meeting in Mangalore as his aircraft spent nearly two hours on the ground in Mumbai and he missed a connecting flight. Frequent fliers now keep redoing the math on the time needed and lost when they travel. Rahul Chaudhary, Mumbai-based CEO of the Tata Strategic Electronics Division, says, "We have to compensate for airline delays and invariably it is our body that takes the toll." He now frequently sacrifices his

AVERAGE ANNUAL COST OF FUEL WASTAGE IS RS 1,460 CRORE OR NEARLY THE COST OF THE NEW AIRPORT IN BANGALORE

tion turbine fuel (ATF), money and time. The International Air Transport Association (IATA) estimates that for every minute in the air, an aircraft burns \$120 (Rs 4,800) worth of fuel and generates 160 kg of carbon dioxide (CO₂). "At an average 15-minute delay in arrivals at the Delhi and Mumbai airports, this works out to about \$1 million (Rs 4 crore) in unnecessary fuel being burnt, and about 1,400 tonne of CO₂ generated a day," says IATA spokesperson Albert Tjoeng. The math works out to Rs 1,460 crore

sleep at night to board a 6 a.m. flight.

The congestion is already hitting bottom lines and low-cost airlines warn they cannot hold on for long. "Every hour, we circle over the Mumbai or Delhi airport, the ATF spent is the equivalent of losing 25 passengers," says Ajai Singh, MD, Spicejet. The Government blames airlines for some of this chaos because in their hurry to run multiple destinations every day, they end up encroaching into landing slots allotted to others. "This is the reason you see more de-

Did mom say 1 1/2 tbsp of ginger or 2 1/2 ?

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